‘constructive Swadeshi’ and avoid the siren call of boycott or not? For most of the directors who were businessmen and whose commitment to politics was defined at best as ‘simple, pure and honest swadeshi’,[18] VOC’s belligerent policy of taking British colonialism head-on was not an option. Political differences apart, the conflict was also shot through with ego and jealousy. Despite the high regard that at least some of the directors had for VOC, not a few saw him as an upstart, resenting the name and fame that he had won by the dint of his industry, resourcefulness and courage. K.R. Guruswami Aiyar, especially, made no secret of his disdain for VOC: he looked down upon him as a lowly second-grade pleader while he himself was a graduate, a lawyer and a member of the legislature—as he boasted to the governor himself.[19]

The moderate directors disavowed politics and maintained that ‘Business people, men with property and the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company have absolutely no sympathy with the politics of Chidambaram Pillai … [SSNCo] is not a political body. Absolutely there are no politics behind that body, neither in their aims nor in their action. It is a purely business body.’[20] This was disingenuous, if not plain hypocrisy. A company carrying Swadeshi in its name could hardly claim to be apolitical. K.R. Guruswami Aiyar was the opposite pole around which ‘the honest Swadeshis’ rallied and tried to dethrone VOC from his pre-eminent position as the helmsman of the company.[21]

For VOC, the shipping enterprise was an integral part of his larger anti-colonial agenda. After the Surat imbroglio and the frenetic pace of the Swadeshi movement in Tuticorin that directly challenged British imperial interests, a head-on conflict became inevitable. Having floated the company, mobilized moral and material support and put it in a position of strength, VOC had outlived his usefulness for the more moderate-minded directors. His continuation in the company would only provoke the government and bring ruin to it. It was time for him to be eased out.

The tensions between VOC and K.R. Guruswami Aiyar even spilled into the press. The ‘heat generated between the two in Surat had spread to the